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VENTURE CAPITAL

Lux Capital's Peter Hébert thinks VCs aren't countering the federal funding cuts enough

By [Rosie Bradbury](#)

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VCs need to step up their support of American scientists whose federal research funding has been cut, [Lux Capital](#) co-founder Peter Hébert told PitchBook.

As its latest move on this front, Lux is backing [Roadrunner Venture Studios'](#) consortium, a new accelerator-like program to help startups incubated out of national labs in New Mexico, including Los Alamos and Sandia.

"We want to both incentivize and reward brilliant American scientists," said Hébert, but "we can't, of course, do it alone." [At One Ventures](#), [Crosslink Capital](#), [Khosla Ventures](#) and [Playground Global](#) are also investing in the program.

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Lux's campaign stands in contrast to the vocal political streak in Silicon Valley that's been rallying behind federal funding cuts. Most prominently, [Andreessen Horowitz's Marc Andreessen](#) has cheered the moves from President Donald Trump's administration and Elon Musk's Department of Government Efficiency. With the industry split, many firms have stayed on the sidelines or have been reluctant to speak out [about how the funding cuts could stifle the startup ecosystem](#).

"A lot of people recognize the opportunity on the micro level, but as a firm, have been reluctant to do anything on the macro," said Hébert.

Lux Capital has been among the most outspoken and active on this issue. In May, the firm set up the Lux Helpline, an initiative with a \$100 million commitment to support new ventures by academic scientists, in part to address the "sudden funding cuts and the crisis of higher education."

The Trump administration has canceled close to \$3 billion in research grants to the National Institutes of Health and National Science Foundation, and its 2026 budget proposal outlines billions more in funding cuts.

The cuts are particularly damaging to national research labs and university labs, both of which rely heavily on federal funding. Venture funds that are tied to universities have rung alarm bells: [The House Fund](#), which invests in startups in the UC Berkeley ecosystem,

raised \$12 million in just seven days from its LPs in March to offer the university’s scientific community an initial reprieve.

Lux has been talking to more traditional investors to emphasize that seeding scientists is not a philanthropic endeavor, but one with commercial benefits, Hébert said. “We want others to recognize that this is important, this deserves their time, energy and capital.”

“There is a moment right now, and it’s a little bit chaotic, but I think it’s an opportunity that others should seize and join us, and focus on funding matter that matters,” Hébert said.

Featured image by Adriana Hansen/PitchBook News

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About [Rosie Bradbury](#)

Rosie Bradbury is a senior reporter covering startups and venture capital for PitchBook News. Based in New York, she previously reported for the Bureau of Investigative Journalism, Business Insider and Wired. Rosie studied history and politics at the University of Cambridge.

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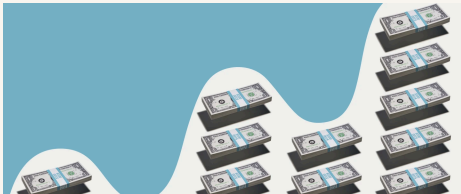
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